

A late night return from a client site in San Diego ensured it was going to be a very early morning and potentially a long day in the lookout if things went slow.

Fortunately when we arrived in Idyllwild things improved markedly as it began to rain on us. In addition as we approached the turnoff for the 243 from the 10 we could see lighting activity off towards the mountains to the north. Maybe things wouldn't be so slow after all.



There weren't many other cars at trailhead

We initially put on our rain gear but the rain was mostly just a nuisance as long as it lasted.



We made it the lookout a little after 8:30 am with plenty of time to open up the cab and get things situated. We had another volunteer working with us that day and he actually arrived while we were taking the weather measurements.



The weather actually improved for a few hours after we went into service. We had enough time to set the chairs out on the catwalk and enjoy the sun for a bit.

The first bit of excitement occurred when a call went out over the radio about a fatal motorcycling accident down on the 74.



The weather had started to improve by late morning with dark clouds starting to form towards San Jacinto. Brad and I were quite encouraged.



We had a small amount of visitors, much less than our previous trip up as the rain and forecast had likely scared a lot of people away. Lightweights.



Always important, lunchtime!



The clouds were quite dark now and I was waiting with little patience for them to let go. There was a sizable cloud above the Jacinto peaks and above our lookout which joined into one large lovely rainclouds



When it did start we had a sudden flood of people coming up to the lookout. We let them up on the catwalk though it was more than we usually allow up there so they could get some amount of cover.



As the rain started a call came across the radio that two climbers had fallen on Suicide Rock.



This is a view of the rock from Devil's Slide. It's quite a bit lower than the lookout but we have a clear view so we had our binoculars out seeing if we could locate the injured hikers.



This is a picture of someone making a whole mess of trouble for himself. Our lookout is in wilderness land and it takes a large amount of paperwork in order to get clearance to land. We're not sure why the pilot touched down on our peak when the injuries were quite a distance away. He was soon notified of his mistake over the radio in rather strong terms.

As the rescue continued we could hear the people on the ground reporting in after finding the hiker who fell 100 feet. They were obviously having a rough time due to the weather and periodically we could hear the injured guy screaming in the background. A helicopter dropped someone down at some point.



The weather had turned rather nasty and it really started to hit us. Instead of a few scattered pieces of hail we now had a full on hail storm



Our visibility went down to effectively zero.

Just as the worst of it hit we actually had two different pairs of hikers arrive on the peak. Per regulations we had to tell them there was an electrical storm bearing down on us and they needed to descend immediately. I'm sure we didn't make anyone's Christmas list as we sent them running down a rocky trail while being pelted by hail.

We radioed in to dispatch that we were going out of service due to severe weather and closed up the cab. We could hear thunder



We did have one more visitor as the storm really got going, another wilderness ranger / lookout volunteer named Joe showed up soaking wet despite his rain gear. We let him in and he rode out the worse of it with us.



Photo op!

It was hard to hear anything over the wind, rain, and hail hitting us but when we cracked the door we could clearly hear thunder almost non-stop.



We thought it was clearing up a bit and actually went outside to get a few pictures. I was on the north side of the catwalk getting ready to take a picture when there was a crack of thunder so loud I just about jumped 2 feet in the air. Apparently had I been looking in the opposite direction I would have seen the flash of a near miss downstrike just down the ridge from us. We went back inside and closed up quite quickly.



Here's the picture through the window. Notice all the hail on the ground between the rocks.



We spent the time sitting on the insulated furniture and listening to the increasingly harried responses from the emergency personnel responding to the fallen climbers.



Joe left as soon as things cleared up hoping to make it out of the wilderness before the weather turned bad again. Kim, Brad, and I went back into service and reported the downstrikes. We soon heard from other wilderness personel that there had been a number of downstrikes which meant we had the binoculars out almost constantly looking for any indication of fire.



For a time it appeared the same storm that went over the top of us was stopping at Jacinto and about to roll back over us. Instead it sadly hit Hemet so while we could see them getting hit with a large amount of rain we actually stayed fairly dry.



DATE 8/31/08 **DAILY LOG** DAY OF WEEK Saturday
Tahquitz Peak Lookout

WILCOSS
 Camped/Walked Total 1400
 Morning Shift 3
 Afternoon Shift _____
 Daily Total _____
 New Yearly Total _____

Rooster on Duty	Time In Tower	Time Out of Tower
Kyle Morgan	8:45 am	9:00 am
Matthew Hengst	8:45 am	12:30
Paul Wells	09:00	

WEATHER		AM	P.M.
Sky Conditions		100%	100%
Clouds: Partly Cloudy, Cloudy, Fog, Rain			
Temperature (°F)		58	60
Humidity (%)		53	59
Wet Bulb		51	54
Dry Bulb		51	54
Wind Speed (MPH)		6	
Wind Direction		E	SW
(Compass dir. from which wind is coming)			
Visibility		10 mi	10 mi
(Poor, Fair, Good, Very Good, Excellent)			

Radio Activity / Administrative Issues	
Time	Message
9:15	1st service - 1st in pattern
12:35	REMOVED HEAVY RAIN & DAIL TO DEPART
12:55	PAUSED HEAVY RAIN & DAIL TO DEPART
13:10	1st HELICOPTER LANDS IN TOWER AREA
14:40	END OF SERVICE - 1st HELICOPTER DEPARTS
15:15	1st SERVICE - 2nd in pattern



The weather was depressingly nice on the hike out though the trail was almost washed out in several places due to all the debris the heavy rains had brought down the mountainside.



13 hours later our most eventful shift was over.